

59 Hannah

The childless woman who poured out her soul to God and gave her son Samuel back to him.

Hannah was one of the two wives of Elkanah of Ephraim. Her rival, Peninnah, had children, but Hannah had none, and every year at Shiloh Peninnah provoked her until she wept. One year Hannah prayed in deep distress and vowed that if God gave her a son, she would give him to the LORD for life. Eli thought she was drunk, then blessed her. God remembered Hannah, and she bore Samuel. When he was weaned she left him at Shiloh and sang a song of praise later echoed in Mary's song.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Channah</i> , "grace" or "favor"
Family	Wife of Elkanah; mother of Samuel and five more (1 Samuel 2:21)
When	Late in the judges; Samuel born c. 1100 BC (rough)
Key places	Ramah in mount Ephraim; Shiloh
Key people	Elkanah, Peninnah, Eli, Samuel
Known for	Her prayer, her vow and her song (1 Samuel 1:10–11; 2:1–10)
Main passages	1 Samuel 1:1–2:21
New Testament	Not named; her song is echoed in Luke 1:46–55

"For this child I prayed; and the LORD hath given me my petition which I asked of him: Therefore also I have lent him to the LORD; as long as he liveth he shall be lent to the LORD. And he worshipped the LORD there."

1 Samuel 1:27–28, KJV

The life of Hannah

Dates are rough; the house chronology places Samuel's birth c. 1100 BC.

Year by year	● Provoked at Shiloh Elkanah loves Hannah, but Peninnah provokes her because the LORD has shut up her womb. Hannah weeps and will not eat. <i>1 Samuel 1:1-9</i>
At the temple	● Prays and vows In bitterness of soul she vows to give a son to the LORD for life. Eli thinks she is drunk, then blesses her. <i>1 Samuel 1:10-18</i>
c. 1100 BC At Ramah	● Samuel is born She bears a son and names him Samuel, "Because I have asked him of the LORD." <i>1 Samuel 1:19-23</i>
After weaning	● Gives Samuel to the LORD She brings him to Shiloh and tells Eli, "For this child I prayed," lending him to the LORD. <i>1 Samuel 1:24-28</i>
That day	● Sings her song She rejoices in God's salvation: he humbles the proud, raises the poor, and will exalt his anointed. <i>1 Samuel 2:1-10</i>
Each year after	● More children She brings Samuel a little coat each year. The LORD visits her, and she bears three sons and two daughters. <i>1 Samuel 2:18-21</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Hannah speaks of God exalting "the horn of his anointed" (1 Samuel 2:10) before Israel has any king. Some read this as looking ahead to Israel's kings, others as pointing beyond them to the Messiah; many see both.

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- 1 Worshipped faithfully.** She went up to Shiloh year after year, even though the trip brought her pain. *1 Samuel 1:3-7*
 - 2 Endured provocation.** Peninnah "provoked her sore," yet Scripture records no reply from Hannah. *1 Samuel 1:6-7*
 - 3 Poured out her soul.** She brought her grief to God in prayer and tears. *1 Samuel 1:10, 15*
 - 4 Made a vow.** She promised to give her son to the LORD for life. *1 Samuel 1:11*
 - 5 Answered respectfully.** When Eli accused her, she explained herself gently and did not argue. *1 Samuel 1:14-16*
 - 6 Left her burden with God.** After Eli's blessing she ate, "and her countenance was no more sad." *1 Samuel 1:18*
 - 7 Named her son.** She called him Samuel as a reminder that she had asked him of the LORD. *1 Samuel 1:20*
 - 8 Kept her vow.** She weaned Samuel, then brought him to Shiloh and left him in the LORD's service. *1 Samuel 1:24-28*
 - 9 Sang God's praise.** "There is none holy as the LORD: for there is none beside thee." *1 Samuel 2:1-2*
 - 10 Cared from a distance.** Each year she made Samuel a little coat and brought it to him. *1 Samuel 2:19*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Hannah.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 1:1–2:21	The main account
Echo: Genesis 21:1–2; 25:21; 30:22–24	Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel given children
Echo: Judges 13:2–3	Samson's mother, also once barren
Echo: Psalm 113:7–9	Lifting the poor; "the barren woman" made joyful

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:46–55	Mary's song follows the pattern of Hannah's
Echo: Luke 1:7, 13	Elizabeth, long childless, bears a promised son
Echo: Luke 2:36	Anna bears the Greek form of Hannah's name
Echo: 1 Peter 5:7	"Casting all your care upon him"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Hannah describe what she was doing when Eli thought she was drunk (1 Samuel 1:15–16)?
2. *Understand:* Hannah asked God for a son, then gave him back. What does that show about how she saw her gift?
3. *Apply:* Hannah took her deepest pain to God in honest prayer. What would it look like for you to pour out your soul to God this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there something God has given you, such as a child, a skill or your time, that you need to offer back to him?